STAGE FIVE · THINKING, REASONING & MENTAL MODELS

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Live, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from interaction

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource · Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Five • Thinking, Reasoning & Mental Models

PURPOSE

Stage Five's thirty FIRSTS are written as solo reasoning exercises — build your own matrix, map your own system, audit your own biases. But the whole premise of a cognitive bias, or a blind spot in a decision matrix, is that it's genuinely hard to see from the inside. This is one of the stages where outside perspective isn't just a nice addition; it's often the only way to actually catch what the exercise is looking for.

This document adapts seven FIRSTS across all four sessions into pair or small-group formats. As always, these are additions, not replacements — participants complete their own individual reasoning first, and the group version tests or sharpens it. Several of these (the Decision Matrix weight-check, the Critical Thinking steelman swap) work specifically because a peer isn't invested in your particular answer the way you are.

Each entry includes a suggested format, the extra time it adds beyond the solo version, numbered steps you can read almost verbatim to a group, and a short note on why the live version specifically matters for that FIRST.

The Seven Adapted Exercises

FIRST G4

Decision Matrix — *Peer Weight-Check*

TIME: +15 min beyond solo build

1. After building their own matrix individually, pairs swap matrices without discussing the underlying decision first.
2. Partner reviews the weights and criteria only, and guesses which option the weights seem to favor before knowing the person's actual preference.
3. Compare: did the guess match the original preference? If so, discuss whether the weights were chosen honestly or reverse-engineered.

> FACILITATOR NOTE
> *This directly surfaces the exact pitfall this FIRST warns about, choosing weights that favor a predetermined answer, in a way that's much harder to notice in your own matrix alone.*

FIRST G6

Critical Thinking Drill — *Steelman Swap*

TIME: +15 min beyond solo analysis

1. Each person brings one real claim they've recently encountered and privately agree with.
2. Pairs swap claims and each identifies the unstated assumptions in their partner's claim, not their own.
3. Discuss: is it easier to spot assumptions in a claim you don't have a personal stake in?

> FACILITATOR NOTE
> *This directly targets the FIRST's named pitfall — using critical thinking only on claims you disagree with. Analyzing someone else's claim you don't personally hold a stance on reveals how much easier scrutiny becomes without personal investment.*

FIRST G9

Cognitive Bias Audit — *Outside Mirror*

TIME: +15 min beyond solo reflection

1. Groups of 3. Each person describes one real recent decision they made, without naming what bias (if any) they suspect was involved.
2. The other two group members each suggest one bias they think might have been at play, based only on the description.
3. Compare the outside guesses to the person's own self-assessment: did anyone catch something the person had missed?

> FACILITATOR NOTE
> *Self-assessed bias audits are inherently limited, since the whole nature of bias is that it's hard to*

> *see in yourself. An outside perspective genuinely catches things solo reflection alone tends to miss.*

FIRST G10

Systems Thinking Exercise *— Collaborative Map-Building*

TIME: +20 min beyond solo mapping

1. Small groups of 3–4 choose one shared, real system relevant to all of them (e.g., their program's registration process, a shared team workflow).
2. Build one shared systems map together on a whiteboard or shared doc, with each person contributing nodes and loops they've personally observed.
3. Compare the collaborative map's complexity to what any one person would likely have mapped alone.

> **FACILITATOR NOTE**
> *Systems are, almost by definition, bigger than any one person's individual view of them. A genuinely shared system mapped collaboratively surfaces loops and connections invisible to any single participant.*

FIRST H16

SWOT Thinking Exercise *— Blind Spot Panel*

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. Groups of 3. Each person shares their Strengths and Opportunities quadrants only (not Weaknesses/Threats) for a real decision.
2. The group suggests one Weakness or Threat they'd genuinely add, based only on what they just heard.
3. Each person decides whether to incorporate the outside perspective.

> **FACILITATOR NOTE**
> *This mirrors a pattern used earlier in the program (Stage One's Career SWOT) and works for the same reason: people are consistently better at spotting blind spots in someone else's analysis than their own.*

FIRST H18

Inversion Thinking Drill *— Failure Auction*

TIME: +15 min beyond solo listing

1. Small groups pool their individual “what would guarantee failure” lists for a shared or similar goal into one combined list.
2. As a group, rank the combined list by which failure mode feels most genuinely likely, not just most dramatic.
3. Each person takes the group's top-ranked risk back to their own plan and names one preventive action.

> **FACILITATOR NOTE**
>
> *A pooled, ranked list surfaces the genuinely probable risks more reliably than one person's individual brainstorm, which tends to either miss things or overweight dramatic but unlikely failures.*

FIRST H27

Comparative Analysis — *Criteria Negotiation*

TIME: +15 min beyond solo scoring

1. Pairs each bring a real decision with 2–3 options. Before scoring individually, negotiate as a pair on what criteria genuinely matter for comparisons like this in general.
2. Each person then scores their own specific options against the jointly negotiated criteria.
3. Discuss: did the negotiated criteria differ from what you would have picked alone, and was that useful?

> **FACILITATOR NOTE**
>
> *Negotiating criteria with another person surfaces implicit assumptions about what matters that are easy to skip past when working entirely alone.*